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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Flurry of bills head to Pritzker for signing

State lawmakers wrap up final days of spring session

By Jeremy Gorner, Addison Wright, Olivia Olander and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Along with a budget that passed shortly before Saturday's deadline, Illinois legislators passed a flurry of bills in the final days of the General Assembly's spring session on issues ranging from police hiring practices to traffic safety.

Here are some of the bills heading to Gov. JB Pritzker's desk after passing out of the legislature at the end of the four-month session.

Regulating pharmacy benefits managers

A measure designed to rein in the practices of pharmacy benefits managers, or PBMs — companies that act as intermediaries between drugmakers, insurance corporations and pharmacies — was approved with broad bipartisan support and is backed by Pritzker.

The largest PBMs are part of corporate entities that include pharmacy chain CVS and UnitedHealth Group. Critics blame them for driving up prescription drug costs for patients while pushing independent pharmacies out of business.

The measure awaiting Pritzker's signature would bar PBMs from charging insurance companies more for drugs than they are paid by pharmacies and pocketing the difference; prohibit them from giving better reimbursement rates to pharmacies that are owned by the same company; and require them to pass along rebates negotiated with drugmakers to health plans and patients.

PBMs also would be required to make annual reports on pricing and other practices to the Illinois Department of Insurance, and would be charged an annual \$15-per-patient fee, with the first \$25 million collected going to a grant fund to support local pharmacies.

"For far too long, pharmacy benefit managers' business practices have operated with little regulation, transparency, and accountability. Illinois is putting an end to that," Pritzker said in a statement Saturday after the House sent the

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People stand at the balcony in the Illinois State Capitol in Springfield on Wednesday. JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS

Pritzker blames Trump for fiscal challenges

After lawmakers pass budget with cuts and tax hikes, governor slams tariff policies, 'chaos and uncertainty'

By Dan Petrella, Jeremy Gorner and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — While offering a sunny take on the passage of a roughly \$55 billion state spending plan balanced in part by cutting back on some of his own priorities, Gov. JB Pritzker on Sunday blamed Illinois' latest fiscal challenges not on a state tax system he once described as "unfair" and "inadequate" but on economic headwinds created by President Donald Trump.

"This year has been hard across the entire Midwest — indeed, the entire country," Pritzker told reporters in his state Capitol office, nodding to cuts in areas such as public health and higher education in neighboring red states Indiana and Iowa.

"Donald Trump's incomprehensible tariff policies have put a tax on our working families and dampened the nation's economic outlook,"



Gov. JB Pritzker answers reporters' questions about the state budget at the Illinois State Library in Springfield on Wednesday.

he said. "The Trump slump is affecting every state, and the chaos and uncertainty of the Republicans' proposed cuts to health care and education and jobs have made budgeting, well, harder than ever before."

The spending plan, which was passed by lawmakers on Saturday shortly before a midnight deadline and awaits

Pritzker's signature before the state's fiscal year begins July 1, makes nearly \$400 million in spending cuts, including \$193 million in operational cuts, beyond what Pritzker proposed in February, according to budget negotiators.

It also relies on increased taxes on tobacco products, online sportsbooks, and over-

seas and out-of-state corporate earnings as well as one-time revenue measures, which together total more than \$800 million.

Pritzker's efforts to blame Trump for Illinois' latest budget woes and contrast the state's spending decisions with those of neighboring Republican-led states came at the end of a spring legislative session during which the governor continued efforts to raise his national profile.

His relentless criticisms of Trump — particularly in a fiery speech to New Hampshire Democrats and appearances on cable news, late-night TV and podcasts — have stood in contrast to the softer tone employed by some other prominent Democratic governors and further fueled speculation Pritzker is eyeing a White House run in 2028.

Before that, however, the billionaire Hyatt Hotels heir must officially decide whether to run next year for a third term as governor. It's widely expected he will, though he didn't answer when asked about it as he departed his

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- Bears stadium efforts run out of time, but suburban lawmaker says deal was close and talks will continue. **Page 2**
- Lawmakers advance bill prohibiting public schools from denying students based on immigration status. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Senators: Putin plans 'more war' in Ukraine

US bipartisan mission warns of stalling, vows sanctions bill

By Thomas Adamson
Associated Press

PARIS — Russian President Vladimir Putin is stalling at the peace table while preparing a new military offensive in Ukraine, two senior U.S. senators warned Sunday, arguing that the next two weeks could shape the future of a war that has already smashed cities, displaced millions and redrawn Europe's security map.

Republican Sen. Lindsey Graham and Democratic Sen. Richard Blumenthal spoke to The Associated Press in Paris after meeting President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Kyiv and touring neighborhoods shattered by what they called the worst



Sen. Lindsey Graham, right, and Sen. Richard Blumenthal speak Friday in Kyiv, Ukraine. On Sunday, they warned that Russian President Vladimir Putin is preparing a new offensive in Ukraine. VASILISA STEPANENKO/AP

Russian bombardments since the full-scale invasion began.

In Paris for talks with French President Emmanuel Macron —

who they say is "100% aligned" with them on the war — the senators warned that the window to prevent a renewed assault is clos-

ing. A sweeping U.S. sanctions bill could be the West's last chance to choke off the Kremlin's war economy, they said, adding that they hope their firsthand findings will shift momentum in Washington and help bring a skeptical President Donald Trump on board.

"What I learned on this trip was, he's preparing for more war," Graham said of Putin.

Blumenthal called the sanctions proposed in legislation "bone-crushing" and said it would place Russia's economy "on a trade island."

"It is crunch time for Putin and for the world because Russia is mounting a new offensive," Blumenthal said.

At the heart of their push is a bipartisan sanctions bill, backed by nearly the entire U.S. Senate but still facing uncertain odds in Washington. It would impose

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INSIDE

Can Trump manage national debt?

The president faces doubts from Republican senators, global investors, voters and even Elon Musk that he won't increase debt with tax breaks. **Nation & World**

FBI labels incident 'terror attack'

Several people were hurt and some may have been set on fire at an outdoor mall in Colorado in what the FBI called a "targeted terror attack." **Nation & World**

The Weeknd closes a chapter in Chicago

The pop artist said goodbye to his persona as The Weeknd and introduced the crowd at Soldier Field to Abel Tesfaye in a concert that thrilled his fans. **Arts & Living**

